LECTURE 4

INDIAN SCHOOLS OF HISTORICAL THOUGHT

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Indology and the Recovery of Ancient Indian History

How was ancient Indian history recovered, and what were the strengths and weaknesses of that recovery?

- **Orientalism**
- **Indology**
- **historical method**
- **Archaeology, epigraphy and numismatics**
- **colonial knowledge and its limits**

Ancient India and the absence of conventional records

- **Medieval India had Indo-Muslim chronicles**
- **Ancient India appeared harder to reconstruct**
- **British scholars claimed there were few "genuine" historical records**
- **Ancient history had to be recovered from indirect sources**

Key terms:
- historical consciousness
- textual evidence
- material evidence
- reconstruction

Reading is important for historiography: it shows history being built from fragments

Orientalism and Indology

- **Indology** is the scientific or systematic study of Indian history, languages, literature, religions, and culture

- **Orientalist influences:**
  - European Enlightenment
  - cultural relativism
  - comparative scholarship
  - Romantic fascination with ancient civilizations
  - colonial administrative needs

Orientalist scholarship helped recover India's ancient past, but it did so within the structures of colonial power

- British Orientalists were shaped by two major European intellectual currents
  - Enlightenment
  - Romanticism

Early British Indological efforts

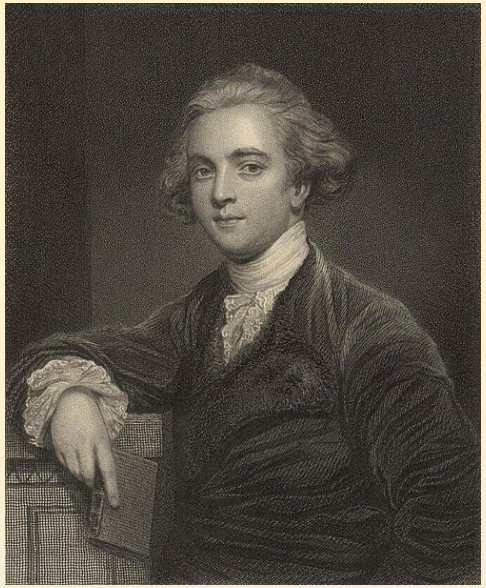
Scholar	Contribution
Robert Orme	Early British historical writing on India
Francis Gladwin	Writings and translations on Mughal India
Nathaniel Halhed	Gentoo Laws and Bengali grammar
Charles Wilkins	Sanskrit studies; translation of the Bhagavad Gita
Jonathan Duncan	Encouraged Hindu learning and scholarship
Warren Hastings	Patron of Orientalist scholarship

Indology emerged from a mixture of curiosity, administrative necessity, patronage, and imperial governance

A crucial figure behind many of these efforts was **Warren Hastings**, the governor-general. He believed British administration in India required knowledge of Indian law, language, and culture

William Jones and the Asiatic Society of Bengal

- **William Jones:**
  - Welsh philologist, & Judge of the Supreme Court at Calcutta
  - Linguist and Orientalist
  - Founder of the Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1784
  - Major translator and organiser of Indological research (translated *Shakuntala*, *Geeta Govinda*, *Manusmriti*)



- **Significance of the Asiatic Society:**
  - institutionalized Indological research
  - encouraged translations
  - supported source collection
  - modelled organised scholarly inquiry

Jones facilitated the study of India into an organised scholarly field. Through the Asiatic Society, Indology became systematic, collaborative, and institutional

Jones's major discoveries: language and chronology

Contribution	Historical importance
Indo-European language theory	Linked Sanskrit with Greek, Latin, Persian, and European languages
Sandrocottas-Chandragupta Palibothra- Pataliputra identification	Gave ancient Indian chronology a fixed point

The identification of Chandragupta Maurya with Sandrocottas became a "sheet anchor" of ancient Indian chronology

Textual scholarship after Jones

Scholar	Area of work
H. T. Colebrooke	Vedas, Sanskrit texts, Hindu law and philosophy
Max Muller	*Rig Veda*, Sanskrit literature, comparative religion- *Sacred Books of the East*
Eugene Burnouf	Pali, Buddhism, Buddhist texts
Rhys Davids	Buddhist literature and Pali studies
Pali Text Society	Publication and study of Buddhist texts

Ancient Indian history was reconstructed through political records, as well as religious, literary, linguistic and philosophical texts. It created methodological challenges: Texts had to be dated, interpreted, compared and used carefully

Orientalism and Indology

- James Princep- deciphered Ashokan inscriptions written in Old Brahmi script. Opened the history of Buddhism and Ashoka's reign to historical investigation

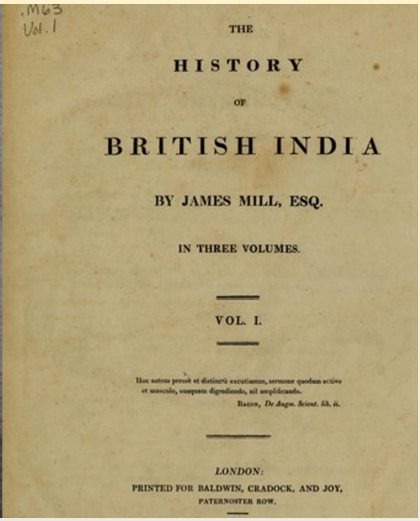
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=h9RdkW7iyWA



James Princep

- James Mill, *The History of British India* (1818, 1820, 1826, 1840, 1848)
  - Tremendous influence on British policies in India
  - Established as a text book in the Haileybury College (1805- 1855)
  - British Indian administrators entertained illusions of the permanence of British rule





- H.H. Wilson- critic of Mill
  - Destroying the relations between the ruler and the ruled
  - Creating aversions for Indians
  - British monopolizing all posts of power and honour in India

- Mountstuart Elphinstone (*History of Hindu and Mohammadan in India*, 1841) - critic of Mill

R.C. Majumdar observes (on *History*): "It would be difficult to name another book, written by one possessing eminent qualifications as a historian, in which so much prodigious labour has been misdirected to produce a historical work which by any canon of criticism does not deserve the name".

Epigraphy and James Prinsep

- **Epigraphy**- the study of inscriptions

- **James Prinsep's contribution:**
  - worked on inscriptions and coins
  - deciphered Brahmi script
  - made Ashokan inscriptions readable
  - transformed Ashoka from legend into historical figure
  - opened new sources for Indian history

The **method changes what historians can know**. The decipherment of a script can open an entire historical world

Archaeology, coins, and Alexander Cunningham

- **Numismatics**- the study of coins

- **Alexander Cunningham:**
  - pioneer of Indian archaeology
  - associated with the Archaeological Survey of India
  - excavated and surveyed sites such as Sarnath, Sanchi, and Taxila
  - studied coins, inscriptions, monuments, and ancient geography
  - treated material remains as "fragments" of lost Indian history

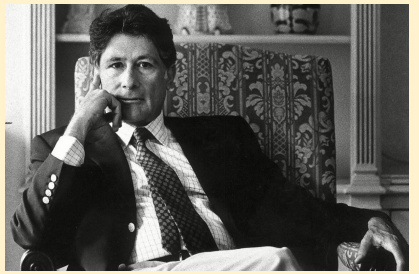
Archaeology transformed Indian history further through the discovery of sites such as Harappa and Mohenjodaro

Significance of the Orientalist recovery

- **Major achievements:**
  - introduced modern historical methods to Indian history
  - developed source criticism, philology, epigraphy, archaeology, and numismatics
  - established chronological anchors
  - revealed ancient Indian literature and philosophy to the world
  - restored India to a major place in world civilization

Sreedharan: **seamy side of Orientalism**?

A comparison with Edward Said



Edward Said (*Orientalism*) analyses: European scholarship about "the East" was not only academic inquiry, but also part of a wider relationship of **power, representation, and colonial authority.** In *Orientalism* (1978), Edward Said argues that "the Orient" was not simply discovered by European scholars. It was also **constructed** through European systems of knowledge.

Meaning	Explanation
An academic field	The study of Asian and Middle Eastern languages, cultures, texts, religions, and histories
A style of thought	A way of dividing the world into "Occident" and "Orient"
A discourse of power	A body of knowledge that helped Europe define, govern, and dominate the East

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7l5CXW2qEfY

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WZXwYpK30zk

Sreedharan's chapter as an example of Orientalist knowledge

Sreedharan's chapter describes how British and European scholars helped recover ancient Indian history through:

- Sanskrit studies
- translations of classical texts
- comparative philology
- archaeology
- epigraphy
- numismatics
- chronological reconstruction

Knowledge and colonial power

Orientalist activity	Colonial function
Translating Hindu law texts	Helped colonial courts administer "native law"
Studying Sanskrit and Persian	Helped officials communicate and govern
Classifying castes, religions, and customs	Made Indian society more legible to the colonial state
Reconstructing ancient chronology	Placed India within a European historical framework
Archaeological surveys	Mapped and catalogued India's past under colonial authority

Said's argument:

- British scholars studied Indian texts partly out of genuine intellectual curiosity
- But that knowledge also helped colonial officials classify Indian society
- Classification made administration easier
- The scholar, translator, judge, collector, and administrator were often connected roles

Sreedharan's chapter can be read fruitfully through Edward Said's *Orientalism*. The Orientalists genuinely contributed to the recovery of ancient Indian history through philology, translation, epigraphy, archaeology, and chronology. Said reminds us that this visibility was produced within colonial power. The India recovered by Orientalist scholarship was also an India classified, translated, textualized, and represented through European intellectual categories. The result was double-edged.

Indian Nationalist School: History as Cultural Vindication

- Developed partly as a response to **British imperialist historiography**
- Sought to defend Indian civilisation against colonial denigration
- Emphasised India's ancient achievements, political traditions, culture, religion, and social institutions
- Re-examined points of Indian history that colonial writers had misunderstood or misrepresented
- Important figures include **R. C. Majumdar**, **K. P. Jayaswal**, **R. G. Bhandarkar**, **H. C. Raychaudhuri**, and others

Marxist School: History as Social and Economic Process

- Became especially influential in the post-independence period
- Used **materialist interpretation** to understand historical change
- Focused on:
  - class relations
  - modes of production
  - agrarian structures
  - surplus extraction
  - caste and economy
  - state formation
- Re-read existing sources with new questions
- Major figures include **D. D. Kosambi**, **R. S. Sharma**, **Irfan Habib**, **Romila Thapar**, **Bipan Chandra** (Marxist-Nationalist), and **Sumit Sarkar**

Cambridge School: Politics, Patronage, and Local Interests

- Associated with historians such as **Anil Seal**, **John Gallagher**, **Gordon Johnson**, and **Christopher Bayly**

- Challenged nationalist interpretations of the freedom movement

- Emphasized:
  - local politics
  - patron-client networks
  - elite competition
  - provincial interests
  - factionalism
  - collaboration and negotiation with colonial power

The Cambridge School usefully highlighted local politics and networks, but critics argue that it underestimated ideology, mass politics, anti-colonial commitment, and popular nationalism

- Saw Indian nationalism less as a unified idealist movement and more as a product of political mobilisation and elite bargaining

Subaltern School: History from Below

- Emerged through the **Subaltern Studies** collective in the 1980s- a historiography of protest
- Associated especially with **Ranajit Guha, Gayatri Spivak**
- Critiqued both:
  - colonial historiography
  - nationalist elite historiography
- Argued that both schools treated Indian nationalism as an elite achievement
- Focused on:
  - peasants
  - workers
  - tribals/adivasis
  - lower castes
  - women
  - marginalized communities
- Emphasised popular initiative, insurgency, consciousness, and autonomous politics

Radically widened the subject of history. Gave agency to people perceived as crowds, mobs, or followers in earlier writing

Indian Schools of Thought at a Glance

Phase	Central concern
Orientalist / Indological	Recovery of ancient India through texts, language, archaeology, inscriptions
Colonial / Imperialist	Justification of British rule through narratives of Indian backwardness
Nationalist	Defense of Indian civilization and national identity
Marxist	Social and economic structures, class, production, material life
Cambridge	Elite politics, patronage, local interests, political networks
Subaltern	Popular agency, protest, marginalised voices, history from below